

How Zak and RP taught England Geometry

As India's two left-arm bowlers came around the wicket, the series took a whole new direction

Legendary jazz composer Duke Ellington would be surprised. One of the most famous songs he wrote has become Verse 1 Chapter 1 of the manual for quick bowling in England. *It don't mean a thing if it ain't got that swing.*

India had plenty and they had it in a package that left Michael Vaughan's men searching for answers. Between them, India's two left-arm pacemen Zaheer Khan and Rudra Pratap Singh took 30 wickets, taking a wicket every eight overs, conceding 23.7 runs per wicket, effective and economical.

In grey, damp conditions, with clouds overhead and humidity in the air, Khan and Singh cracked open the England top six over and over again. The home team crossed a total of 350 only twice in the series. What they did was not just capitalise on the swing

available, but extract more from it, using control, accuracy and variation. Tim Boon, coach of county side Leicestershire where Singh played for a few weeks last season, says, "They have varied the pace, brought the ball into the right-hander, used the bouncer well and reversed it as well."

After being beaten at home for the first time since 2001, England captain Vaughan admitted, "We've been asked different questions against the left-arm angles which we haven't seen before." Bowling conventionally from over the wicket, Khan and his junior colleague Singh were able to bowl both inswing and outswing at the England batsman. The opposition sat up when it was discovered that the Indians could do the same when coming around the wicket and, in fact, Khan could bring the ball in and take it out without changing his action.

They altered what former England bowler Derek Pringle calls the 'geometry' of the left-armer's line of attack, which in any case could give Euclid a headache.

The left-armer is the maverick amongst fast bowlers, the man who at his best can dictate terms to the batsman even before a ball is bowled. In order to sight the bowler coming in at an angle, which is slightly behind the batsman's left shoulder (instead of the right-armers who run in, in line with it), batsmen must open up their stance a little. Boon says, "The angle causes batsmen to change their set-up and decision-making. The trick is to keep your alignment and let the ball come to you, instead of going searching for it."

The Indians had two signature dismissals in Trent Bridge, bowling from around the wicket:

Vaughan was drawn into a nicking Khan to the slips on one that was heading away, and Kevin Pietersen was trapped in front when Singh brought one back in from what looked like the next county to strike him on the pad. Before the final Test of the series at the Oval, England coach Peter Moores called in his former county's left-arm bowler Chris Liddle to bowl at his own batsmen in the nets in order to simulate what the Indian bowlers were doing. Sussex man Liddle could do a reasonable simulation over the wicket, but bowling around the wicket was not even tried.

For former India opener Aakash Chopra says the accurate left armer with the silent menace of swing in his hands must be faced by playing a lot of balls, in front of the pads than beside it. "You have to stay on your front foot so you can prevent

Robin Singh and trainer Greg King organised and ran the net sessions.

Prasad's work with the bowlers was noticed because its impact could be felt immediately where it mattered—the wickets column. After a nightmare first morning, Zaheer Khan finished as top wicket taker, stepping into the shoes of the senior bowler by example. What started as an idea put to Dravid and then tried out in the nets, turned into the tactic that caught the English cold: left-arm bowlers Khan and R.P. Singh using the around-the-wicket angle (*see box*), an unusual line of attack from left-handers. Khan's season with Worcestershire last year brought him 100 wickets, the invaluable experience of bowling in England and controlling

INDIA'S AWAY SERIES WINS

YEAR	OPPOSITION	RESULT*	LED BY
1967-68	NEW ZEALAND	3-1 (4)	M.A.K. PATAUDI
1970-71	WEST INDIES	1-0 (5)	AJIT WADEKAR
1971	ENGLAND	1-0 (3)	AJIT WADEKAR
1986	ENGLAND	2-0 (3)	KAPIL DEV
1993	SRI LANKA	1-0 (3)	M. AZHARUDDIN
2000	BANGLADESH	1-0 (1)	S.GANGULY
2003-04	PAKISTAN	2-1 (3)	S.GANGULY
2003-04	BANGLADESH	2-0 (2)	S.GANGULY
2003-04	ZIMBABWE	2-0 (2)	S.GANGULY
2006	WEST INDIES	1-0 (4)	R. DRAVID
2007	BANGLADESH	1-0 (2)	R. DRAVID
2007	ENGLAND	1-0 (3)	R. DRAVID

* Figures in brackets represent the total number of Tests played in the series

